Aprender a Codificar Manuscritos em um Laboratório de Humanidades

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Learning to Encode Manuscripts in a Humanities Laboratory

The *Research Group on Textual Markup and Editing* (https://matlitlab.uc.pt/oficina/grupo-de-investigacao-sobre-marcacao-textual-e-edicao/) emerged as an initiative within the course *Introduction to Digital Humanities* (IHD), offered by the Faculty of Arts and Humanities at the University of Coimbra. Affiliated with MATLIT LAB: Laboratory of Humanities, GIMTE is composed of undergraduate students in Modern Languages who explore textual encoding as a tool for research and learning using XML-TEI.

Among the group's outcomes is a project involving the creation of a short digital anthology of texts by Fernando Pessoa. The original manuscripts were transcribed and encoded, including ecdotic elements such as textual variants and editorial marks. Additionally, semantic encoding was carried out to identify and organise recurring themes in Pessoa's work, with particular emphasis on reflections on death —a central topic in his poetics. Another noteworthy aspect of the project was the translation of the texts into Romanian, using encoding to represent the specific challenges of literary translation, such as cultural and stylistic nuances. This poster aims to present the methodologies and encoding solutions adopted using the XML-TEI standard.

The challenges encountered—such as representing textual variants and interpreting ecdotic concepts—stimulated theoretical and methodological reflections within the lab: What constitutes a variant? Should one select the first, the second, or the final version? Should Pessoa's original spelling be preserved or modernised? How can abstract concepts be encoded using TEI? These were some of the questions that emerged during the work.

The project was initiated by students, who contributed to the design, transcription of manuscripts, translation, and encoding. Through encoding, students not only acquired technical knowledge but also gained insight into the relevance of digital tools for academic research. The project also illustrates how the integration of digital tools can foster a space for experimentation and methodological innovation. With this poster, we aim to share the process, methodologies, and encoding strategies developed by the group. The experience underscores the importance of initiatives such as MATLIT LAB in creating a playful and experimental pedagogical environment that promotes digital literacy and collaborative learning.

Bibliography

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